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UKS57181_Chapter 2

2

Destination Branding in International Tourism, Croatia

MASTER'S THESIS

Thesis Topic: Destination Branding in International Tourism in Croatia

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2.0 Literature Review

2.1 Introduction

Destination branding has moved past its policy of publicising places to building unique experiences, meanings, and identities for locations, leading to a shaping of perceptions about the same experiences. With respect to global tourism, this has special significance since the identity conveyed by destination management groups is not always in line with the image that is created by travellers based on information and experience received, as well as through social interactions. Thus, to analyse the process of destination branding, it is crucial to learn about both the identity that the destination in question represents and the way it is perceived, and even about the factors that lead to an alignment or mismatch between the two.

This chapter provides a thorough analysis of literature related to destination branding, focusing on such topics as brand identity, destination image, brand personality, positioning components, unique selling propositions, and brand equity. The chapter starts with an evaluation of empirical research studies regarding the ways in which destinations communicate their identities and how tourists subsequently form their perceptions. It goes on to review limitations

and gaps in the existing research, especially regarding combining projected identity and perceived image in the Croatian tourism sector. Moreover, the chapter evaluates and combines the Relational Network Brand Model proposed by Hankinson, Brand Identity Prism created by Kapferer, Destination Image Formation Model proposed by Baloglu and McCleary, and Aaker's Brand Equity Framework to develop the theoretical background of the research. Finally, it creates a conceptual model that links destination branding, tourist perceptions, identity-image alignment, and its implications for sustainable tourism in Croatia.

2.2 Literature Review

2.2.1 Empirical literature

Theme 1: Branding attributes of the destination and tourism-driven campaign communication

Hanna, Rowley, & Keegan (2020) believe a destination's brand is developed based on several functional qualities, emotional features, stories and symbols instead of simply advertising its attractions. In a systematic analysis within the literature involving destination branding, they investigate the interrelatedness of brand identity, brand image, brand personality, brand history and brand communication or media in connection with destination branding. However, they emphasise that the interdisciplinary nature of the field has led to a scattered body of research on the topic. This insight is important, since it implies that the features of the campaign should be viewed as the integrated expression of the destination identity and not as individual promotional components.

As per notions shared by Lalicic et al. (2020), empirical evidence shows an increasing significance of emotions in DMO communication. The research examines social media communications of the 10 most sought-after

destinations in Europe and found 14 common emotional values communicated through Twitter, with the word 'honest' being employed 655 times, followed by the word 'fresh' 500 times and 'glamorous' 462 times. The authors also indicate through their findings that responses differ on Facebook and Twitter, which means that it is not adequate to include the attribute, but it is important how and where it is communicated.

Mandagi, Centeno, & Indrajit (2021) further show how destination branding is multidimensional. The authors initiate their research with a sample of 366 tourists from North Sulawesi and an independent validation sample of 343 tourists. They developed a 19-item brand gestalt scale composed of stories, experiences, environments, and stakeholders. This contradicts attribute-based methods that see branding in terms of a number of advertising claims, as destination meaning arises from the interaction of a number of elements and agents.

Likewise, Dedeoğlu et al. (2020) employed a structural equation modelling approach in a study of 568 tourists who visited Alanya, and they identified that their social media activities positively impacted the brand awareness of the destination. Thus, an event's characteristics are not delivered only through the campaigns of the destination management organisations; in fact, the contribution of tourists in forming a brand image can be observed as well. The analysis of 114 primary articles by Tran & Rudolf (2022) reaffirms the aforementioned tendency, and the researchers identify the destination branding strategy and its components, which include customer-created content and other cognitive, emotional, and behavioural components. As a result, the collected evidence implies that the assessment of Croatia's promotion campaign should not be performed through the lens of only

promoting its attractions, but also the emotional values, stories, experiences, and symbolic meanings related to those attractions.

Theme 2: Factors which influence international tourists' destination image

According to Choi, Hickerson, & Kerstetter (2017), destination image is not merely established through destination marketing, but it is contributed to through a combination of information, personal knowledge, and travel experiences. Within their research-based experiment of a 2*2*3 design, the authors established that information-related messages on the source of travel-related understandings produced variances in psychologically relevant aspects, thereby allowing the credibility of information to positively correlate with destination image and intentions of travelling. The findings of this research bring into question the presumption that exposure to advertising leads to developing favourable opinions among tourists.

Molinillo et al. (2018) recognised how digital media has turned into a significant curator of images, yet the impact seems to vary. They studied DMO websites alongside social media platforms and discovered that tourist participation positively affects cognitive as well as affective image, with cognitive image having a more profound meaning in social networks. Lin et al. (2021), for their part, have completed a comparative research project, which compared the results of 1,336 tourist surveys with 11,775 Flickr images alongside their metadata. There is a clear overlap which has been observed in the results of both studies; nevertheless, social media data offered more diversified and accurate information on destinations as compared to surveys, which contained a greater number of emotional evaluations and personal perceptions. This shows that it is impossible to use only one information source for accomplishing the task of economic image.

As opined by Casali et al. (2020), holidaymakers do not absorb the media information passively. In their research conducted in the region of Molise in Italy, they revealed considerable variations regarding the effects of familiarity, images providing impressions on an emotional and cognitive level, and intentions for actions among different groups of people. This suggests that familiarity is not the same for audiences, and this question casts doubt on the existing theories of how images are created. This is of great importance when it comes to international visitors who are going to Croatia and their pre-existing knowledge about the country, which significantly differs from person to person. Hamdy, Zhang, & Eid (2023) believed that there exists more in addition to the modifications caused by experiences as denoted earlier. In fact, they studied 613 respondents of diverse nationalities and demonstrated that motivation which arises from destinations influences their image, while tourists' experience moderates these links depending on whether visitors are newcomers or experienced travellers. Recent studies have also demonstrated that the accepted image of the destination needs to align with the advertised one. An example of this study would be that of a tourism management company, which utilised ads and opinions from social networks about Hainan and found that consistent images attract tourists' attention to destinations; however, travellers' level of experience prevents the same. As a result, the available data suggests that the image of a given destination should be seen as the result of several factors: credibility of information provided, digital exposure to pictures, prior knowledge, motivation to visit a destination, including experiences gained.

Theme 3: Destination's projected brand identity and its perceived image

According to Ferrer-Rosell & Marine-Roig (2020), the statement that destination branding is experienced solely on the basis of promotional communication remains only partially corroborated, with negligible

disagreement from other distinguished authors. Both authors' research papers tested the images of the destination 'Barcelona' generated by two different sources, comparing both the official tourism press materials and one Lonely Planet guide, apart from other 70,000 TripAdvisor reviewers' comments, making up a total of about 5.8 million words. The findings of this research showed significant differences between the official and tourist-generated image of a given place. Thereby indicating that represented images of the destinations constructed by destination marketing organisations do not usually reflect tourists' perceptions of those places.

A similarity in evidence was noted by Duan et al. (2020), who studied three rural tourism destinations situated near China's Yangtze River Delta, by means of the relationship between official websites, business websites, online reviews, and on-site visitor information. The differences between the sources are apparent from the values allocated to some of the attributes. For instance, official websites provided 5.73% of all the identified image nodes to location characteristics and only 3.12% to attractions. Meanwhile, online visitor reviews gave only 0.50% and 1.78%. Contrastingly, on-site visitors linked the destinations with the 'relaxing' attribute at 10.50%. These findings indicate that there are multiple information sources within the demand side, and the perceived image may differ among those sources.

Comparable findings are presented by Duan et al. (2020), who studied the expected and perceived images of rural tourism destinations in the Yangtze River Delta of China. It has been found that attractions have a share of 6.25% in the expected image, while the geographical background accounts for 3.77% in the expected image; however, in the online comments of visitors, these two indicators contribute 1.78% and 0.50%, respectively. The most interesting fact is that the variable 'destination is relaxing' received 10.50% for proximity to the

image representing the destination, as expressed by on-site visitors, while it comprises only 0.76% of visitors' comments online. This finding implies that the projected image of the destination is not always consistent with the visitors' perception and also illustrates the fact that the perceived image does not exist in the same form across all sources of information. Thus, this finding is of great importance for destination branding research, since it warns against treating one source generated by a tourist as the ultimate source of the destination image.

As opined by Sun, Tang, & Liu (2021), the above argument is bolstered based on the distinction involving the efficacy of communication by the Australian NTO, with the tourist-generated materials served by the Chinese. Moreover, their analysis featured 600 travel-oriented blogs with NTO-circulated social media content, which recognised five categories of cognition and four dimensions of emotion, while the analysis revealed a number of discrepancies between reality and images. More importantly, it also indicated that the phenomenon of incongruence involving images functions at the cognitive and emotional levels, rather than implying that the images presented differ in virtue of different attractions mentioned. On the other hand, the researchers also reminded that the number of discrepancies does not indicate a failure of branding efforts. Qu et al. (2022) also found important discrepancies with regard to the primary nodes of both projected and perceived image networks while studying repeat visitors in Hangzhou; the authors point out that the results of their investigation may vary due to market segmentation and destination attachment that tourists have in mind. Similarly, Li et al. (2023) examined marketing messages against 83,333 reviews of 193 Hainan attractions. The research concluded that higher congruence of image had a positive effect on tourists' evaluation of their experience, though tourist expertise, message

readability, and external crises may influence the results. Consequently, establishing identity and perception coherence was only appropriate and helpful in measuring the strength of the relationship between the two concepts, rather than simply assuming that an increase in the level of consistency will have a favourable effect on people's perceptions. In Croatia's case, this gives grounds for examining the identity of the CNTB or Croatian National Tourist Board, in comparison to the image of Croatia formed by international tourists, but with consideration of the impact of surrounding experiences, sources of information, and audience.

Theme 4: Destination-driven branding and international competitive positioning

According to Lin et al. (2023), destination branding brings competitive advantage by recognising differences that might seem relevant to tourists. Nevertheless, research shows that merely having more destination features does not guarantee differentiation. The authors found clear evidence of the effect of destination branding on tourists' behaviour by examining several destinations. As a result, they show that the concept of positioning actually becomes valuable in a competitive way when a brand allows customers to have unique experiences with it rather than just being an advertisement. Their study employs many destinations, thus proving its overall applicability, although the reliance on intention rather than actual visitation limits the implications in terms of long-term competitiveness.

Cervova & Vavrova (2021) believe that brand equity offers a basis for destination positioning, through which it can add competitive value. For instance, the scholars surveyed with 451 Czech tourists in the Croatian setting and established four dimensions of customer-based destination brand equity such as awareness, image, quality and loyalty. Their factor analysis showed that

the identified characteristics explained from 55% to 82% of the variance in the dimensions, and awareness alone accounted for 72.18% of the variance in the awareness dimension. Furthermore, the image dimension yielded Croatia-specific factors that included attractions, thus showing that destination competitiveness cannot be assessed based on general brand equity principles alone.

As per the notions of Yang, Li, & Choe (2022), a strong branding position does not necessarily allow an indiscriminate form of expansion involving destination identities. The authors utilised information from 423 respondents in Macao and applied tourist review analysis, which allowed them to reveal several forms of destination branding identities that influence positive attitudes and loyalty intentions, while the consistency in personality coherence does not play a significant role at all. The above is especially important for the diversification of tourism products, since reinforcing competition is possible only if new tourism identities remain significantly consistent with the general identity of destinations.

Meanwhile González-Rodríguez et al. (2023) argued that competitiveness literature can question static interpretations featuring competitive advantage involving destination brands. The authors verified the same by conducting research on 137 countries and found that comparative advantage does not automatically lead to competitive advantage. The existence of attractive resources alone is not enough, as it is managers who ultimately exploit those resources towards creating competitive performance. Similarly, Chen et al. (2025), relying on six years of user-generated information, showed that the factors influencing competitive advantage across destinations vary over time. Taken together, these insights imply that Croatia's competitive advantage on global markets is based not only on its tourism attractions, but also on its

ability to transform them into an integrated and appealing branded experience for consumers. Thus, it can be argued that in situations where the projected identity corresponds to the perceived image, the concept of branding has a chance for validation as an effective means of differentiation.

2.2.2 Conceptual literature

Strategic conceptualisation of destination branding

Ruiz-Real, Uribe-Toril, & Gázquez-Abad (2020) convey that destination branding is different from destination marketing because branding is about the formulation of meaning, connections, and identity, while marketing is about promoting and informing about the offers. Recent scholarly works define destination branding in a more comprehensive manner, where the scope of branding encompasses not only promotion but also positioning, image, stakeholders' relations, and experiences forming brand meanings. As explained in the bibliometric study, the promotion of the place, experience, sense of belonging, and consumer-based brand value are some of the main trends in contemporary studies of branding and establish the motivation to shift from communication-based views on branding to its relational-experience-based interpretations.

This wider understanding is further corroborated by the investigation conducted by Hanna, Rowley, & Keegan (2020), who conducted a systematic analysis of 553 studies and discovered seven important themes, such as identity/image/personality, communication and media, politics, heritage, and infrastructure. As a result, their findings reveal the interdisciplinary fragmentation of the field, making it hard to agree on any strictly promotional definition of the destination brand. Additionally, the research by Escobar-Farfán, Cervera-Taulet, & Schlesinger (2024) mapped 295 Scopus-indexed articles on destination branding and marked co-creation, digital

communication, cultural identity, and sustainability as key themes of research in this field. Hence, destination branding is regarded as a complex process of positioning used by stakeholders, which involves creating distinct meanings for destinations instead of informing consumers about certain tourism offers. This makes it possible to analyse the concepts of identity, image, and positioning, which are related to one another.

Destination brand identity

According to Escobar-Farfán, Cervera-Taulet, & Schlesinger (2024), the concept of destination brand identity is based on the meaning and particular associations that a destination wants its audience to form, rather than on the audience's own perceptions of that destination. However, current literature gives rise to doubts about the traditional notion of identity as something constant, in the hands of the destination's management. This is demonstrated within the bibliometric study of 349 peer-reviewed publications conducted by the authors; it was found that there are multiple domains of research, including the communication and digital technologies sector, co-creation programs, and cultural identity and sustainability, which proves that the theory of identity construction is broader than the transmission of the message made by the destination's management. Also, the researchers mention that the universality of destination brand identity is questionable due to the disagreement on the basic elements of identity.

This concept change is important for realising project identity. DMOs or destination management organisations may express functional features, cultural values, and symbolic meanings, but identity is perceived more and more as a result of interaction among the stakeholders. Hay, Chien, & Ruhanen (2022) argue that the destination branding process can ignore local inhabitants, resulting in identities which do not incorporate emotional and meaningful

connotations associated with the place involved in destination planning for tourists. Considering the same, identity cannot only be seen in terms of campaign content, since it is a strategic goal being negotiated in the wider environment of stakeholders. Therefore, within the context of the study, projected destination identity is defined as the qualities, values, character, and cultural significance of the Croatian tourist authorities' message to the public, taking into consideration the fact that these attributes will later be interpreted by foreign audiences. This difference provides a theoretical foundation for the analysis of whether Croatia's intended identity coincides with its perceived destination image.

Destination brand perception using image

Yang et al. (2022) consider a destination's brand image by referring to the public's ideas about what a destination looks like, unlike in the case of brand identity, which is about the way a destination wants to appear. More recently, thorough investigations led to the finding that image should not be treated as an uncomplicated and unchanging construct. The scholars also argued about the necessity to consider the existence of components of destination image; they also expressed doubts concerning the way the above-mentioned components function in different cultures.

Zhang et al. (2023) also explored the concept of multidimensionality by corroborating it through empirical observations. They investigated 39,117 images from tourists and proved the correlation between cognitive characteristics of destination and eight affective characteristics, which can be viewed as evidence that tourists' visual information may serve to communicate both cognitively and emotionally. In all respects, the scientific research which was conducted in connection with sensory aspects supports the claim that destination image contains more than cognitive and emotional contents by

presenting a hierarchical model which includes sensory, cognitive, conative, and affective sides of destination image creation (Trang et al., 2023).

Stylidis (2022) believes that an image should not be perceived simply as a passive result of promotional communications. Providing data from two different destinations indicates that touristic interactions with local 'more knowledgeable others and peoples' values related to attractions can help in modifying cognitive, affective and conative images. Additionally, Chang and Ko (2024), in their study of 25,952 TripAdvisor reviews conducted together with the survey analysis, found that cognitive, affective, and conative images do not have the same weight depending on the level of psychological distance. Consequently, the image of a destination can be better understood as potentially dynamic, multidimensional, and audience-related perception, which highlights important conceptual differences between the projected image of Croatia and the tourists' perceived image.

Brand personality involving destinations and its symbolic association Wang et al. (2022) believe destination brand personality associates places with qualities that are human-like in nature, thereby aiding travellers to make connections between places instead of evaluating them merely under utilitarian terms. In recent times, many have found evidence negating the notion that personality could only be seen as certain personality traits. The study conducted by the authors involved the use of an experimental version of neuroscience with 34 participants (18 potential and 16 actual tourists); it was shown that the experience encountered by tourists in a particular location could influence how they recognise destination-personality relationships and thus form some kind of personality, which is shaped through experience rather than only being imposed by tourism marketers.

Indications through cross-cultural examples also embody differences in perception of individual characteristics. Within the research, Güzel, Ünal, & Şahin (2022) collected opinions of 1688 British, Russian, German and Turkish tourists in Antalya, leading to the establishment of four variables characterising destination personality, such as excitement, sincerity, androgyny, and competence. Thus, personality serves as a symbolic link between identity and image, though it is interpreted differently by different people. As a result, the situation in this specific case of Croatia requires treating personality not just as a set of features used in advertisement, but also as a symbolic representation of tourism character, which can be interpreted differently among target markets.

2.3 Gaps in literature

Even with substantial progress within destination-centred branding-related scholarly works, there remain many interconnected gaps specific to the current study. They can be as follows.

Firstly, the literature seems to reflect divided opinion about different phases of destination branding. One of its bibliometric studies involving 295 Scopus-indexed publications highlights eight major areas of research, including communication and digital technologies, co-creation, cultural identity, sustainability, dimensionality, and being satisfied with the destination (Escobar-Farfán, Cervera-Taulet, & Schlesinger, 2024). Although separating these areas of research implies that destination identity, tourist perception, and strategic outcomes have been investigated as different streams of research with links to one another, they have not yet been studied in an integrative approach. Thus, they might be regarded as important topics for investigating the chain of events starting from projected destination identity

and moving to perceived destination image, and further to competitive positioning of the destination.

Secondly, a methodological gap exists when linking branding from the perspective of supply with branding from the perspective of demand. Recent comparative studies have revealed the importance of a joint analysis of the two types of images. For instance, in 2024, research on the Lake Lucerne Region used 300 images in the context of DMO and tourists' posts, collected from a database of over 10,000 posts (Geyer, Zimmermann, & Wyss, 2024). Although the research showed significant similarities between the way organisations and tourists present images, the research focuses on visual social media content, and the question of whether such alignment persists when tourists' perceptions are directly measured remains unanswered. The current research aims to eliminate this gap by combining the technique of critical analysis of methods used by CNTB and in-depth interviews conducted with international tourists, thus enabling the comparison of projected and perceived images.

Thirdly, despite the existence of destination branding research in Croatia, there are still critical contextual issues which need to be addressed. There have been customer-based destination brand equity studies on 451 Czech tourists in Croatia, where the dimensions of awareness, image, quality, and loyalty have been identified. The findings suggested that these dimensions account for 55%-82% of the variance across these dimensions (Cervova & Vavrova, 2021). However, this study is about brand equity, and it does not look beyond Croatia's self-promoted identity to explore how tourists perceive Croatia as a destination. Similarly, the study of Croatia's brand has been conducted on the basis of two samples of 200 respondents: 100 Croatians and 100 foreign respondents from 30 different countries (Ivanković, Mitrović, & Tadić, 2024). However, the emphasis of the study was on nation branding and not on the

relationship between Croatia's tourism marketing and its destination image on a wider international scale.

Finally, the literature does not adequately link destination branding with sustainability and diversification. Research conducted in 11 coastal destinations involving eight countries around the Mediterranean Sea confirms that sustainability-related clustering is influenced by the seasonality of the destination, dependence on tourism, accommodation configuration, and visitor profile. Such information can help develop competitive destination positioning (Glyptou et al., 2022). Nonetheless, destination branding focusing on sustainability is still an emerging area of research, as indicated by a systematic review published in 2024 that draws attention to the necessity of increasing the integration between sustainability branding and visitor response with destination outcomes (Garanti, Ilkhanizadeh, & Liasidou, 2024). Hence, the main question is whether Croatia can implement a better-formed identity to continue differentiating itself from its competitors, instead of strengthening its existing tourism demand. This study aims to address the above assumptions by integrating projected identity with international tourist perception, identity-image integration, and its influence on Croatia's competitiveness and potential tourism diversification (Garanti, Ilkhanizadeh, & Liasidou, 2024).

2.4 Theoretical framework

Graham Hankinson's 'Relational Network Brand Model' shows how destination branding can be considered as a network of relationships, instead of simply being a communication process controlled by destination management organisations (Hankinson, 2004). In this way, the destination brand is considered as a result of the relationships between the brand owner, stakeholders, consumers, and the experiences taking place within the

destination, thereby allowing a shift in focus from advertising messages to the actions and interactions for producing brand meanings.

Contemporary empirical investigations validate the importance of this relationship-based perspective. Saraniemi & Komppula (2017) show in their analysis of destination brand development through stakeholder partnerships that destination brand identity arises from the interaction of stakeholders and is not solely imposed through destination management practices. Moreover, the importance of their results stems from the fact that empirical studies on stakeholder participation in destination branding are still scarce. Outcomes generated by Perkins, Khoo-Lattimore, & Arcodia (2020) match findings of Saraniemi & Komppula (2017), revealing that individual tourism firms may interpret and develop their own views on the destination brand, which leads to an unclear brand message.

In the case of Croatia, Hankinson's model suggests that CNTB or the Croatian National Tourist Board, represents only one part of the broader network of destination brands. The model is advantageous for this study because it allows us to consider the projection of the brand not merely as campaign content, but provides a theoretical base for exploring how corporate communication interacts with experiences and perceptions of the stakeholders regarding the tourist destination in question (Hankinson, 2004).

The 'Brand Identity Prism' proposed by Jean Kapferer in 1992 presents an organised manner of putting into practice destination identity through six interlinked dimensions, which are: physique, personality, culture, relationship, reflection and self-image (Kapferer, 1992, pp. 155-275). The significance of this model for this research is determined by the fact that it allows going beyond listing the promotion characteristics of Croatia as a destination, and instead analysing the connotations embedded in those characteristics (Kapferer, 1992,

pp. 200-290). Thus, physique is connected to the actual features of Croatia in terms of visual and geographical characteristics; personality relates to the human characteristics that branding indicates in the context; culture is connected to the underlying values and heritage in the context; and relationship, reflection, and self-image deal with social aspects in the context. Recent empirical research proves the significance of researching destination identity through several identity-related constructs. A study carried out in Taiwan in 2023 concerning the Pier-2 Art Centre, in which confirmatory factor analysis and structural equation modelling methods were used to explore the concept of destination brand identity, helped to discover the coefficient value 0.90 ($R^2 = 0.81$) connected to brand self-concept and 0.86 ($R^2 = 0.739$) concerning brand perception (Chiang & Chen, 2023). It was shown in the research that visitors' identity-related values serve as vital elements of destination brand identity and not as marginal promotional results. Taking into account the experience of using Kapferer's prism in the research featuring Croatia, this principle could serve as an analytical coding scheme that will allow an understanding to permeate what CNTB promotes as Croatia's identity and make further comparisons with the image of the destination as perceived by international tourists.

The 'Destination Image Formation Model' developed by Seyhmus Baloglu and Ken McCleary in 1999 remains a key theoretical base that can explain the process of forming perceptions about Croatia among international tourists (Baloglu & McCleary, 1999, pp. 35-62). According to this model, two types of factors exist. On the one side, stimulus factors come into play, i.e. the sources of information and previous experience. On the other hand, personal factors come into play, i.e. psychological and social characteristics that come to define cognitive and affective evaluations. Modern studies confirm the validity of the

sequence in question. Marques, Vinhas da Silva & Antova (2021) conducted a study involving 314 foreign tourists visiting Sofia, showcasing how the cognitive image significantly influenced many behavioural intentions.

Moreover, other evidence substantiates the assertion that image creation occurs from more than mere responses towards marketing messages. In their research, Sabiote-Ortiz, Alberto, & Frías-Jamilena (2024) posited that people's self-efficacy regarding the use of information influenced the process of forming an image representing a certain destination, although the impact of the cognitive and affective components differed depending on the stage of crisis. Likewise, in their work carried out in 2021 and involving 375 respondents, it was revealed that participants' mental imagery and interaction with 360-degree presentations affected the cognitive and affective components of the formation of the image (Wu & Lai, 2021). Therefore, the suggested model helps study how the exposure of international tourists to information related to their personality traits and experiences comes together with cognitive and affective perceptions surrounding Croatia. Thus, it creates a theoretical foundation for the survey measure.

The 'brand equity framework' introduced in 1991 by David Aaker has considered the strength of a brand to comprise aspects such as brand fame, perceived quality, brand association, and brand loyalty, which helps to regard a destination value as something more than just a final goal in itself (Aaker, 1991, pp. 85-134). Nowadays, research in tourism supports this idea but emphasises that destination brand equity is far more complex than Aaker has defined it previously. For instance, Ekinci et al. (2022) revealed that destination brand equity is made up of six components: brand awareness, service and value quality, self-congruity, endorser credibility, brand trust, and brand loyalty, by involving 250 respondents in Indonesia and 246 respondents in the UK who

took part in the research. This also confirmed psychometric properties within the factors that influenced trust towards a destination and influenced its image in the mind of tourists.

Similarly, in research involving 460 visitors to Sanya, China, it was found that the influence of destination brand experience on emotions and brand credibility resulted in shaping tourists' overall evaluation of brand equity (Shizhen et al., 2024). Thus, Aaker's model has proved to be useful not only for measuring whether Croatia is known to visitors, but also for assessing whether the communicated identity yields quality perception, associations, as well as loyalty-related outcomes among tourists. Here, there is a theoretical connection between Croatia's projected identity, as one tourist perceives it, and the possible competitive advantage from enhanced destination branding. All four theoretical frameworks offer a sequential, but not linear pattern of reasoning behind this study. Hankinson positions Croatia's destination brand in the context of a network of organisational, stakeholder, and consumer relationships, thus countering the DMO-led version of branding (Hankinson, 2004). Kapferer then lays out the analytical framework for interpreting the different dimensions of these relations, especially for communicating identity through physique, personality, culture, relationships, reflections and self-image (Kapferer, 1992, pp. 62-120). Then, Baloglu and McCleary direct analytical attention away from what Croatia says to how these messages are interpreted by foreign tourists in formulating their cognitive and emotional image (Baloglu & McCleary, 1999, pp. 35-62). Finally, Aaker studies whether perceptions provide substantive brand value through awareness, quality, associations and loyalty. Most importantly, the models help to achieve a complementary, but not interchangeable, analysis of ideas (Aaker, 1991, pp. 85-134). Thus, identity does not imply image compatibility, and a positive image does not equal brand value.

This combination of models allows investigating the relationship between identity and image as well as its strategic implications for Croatia's tourism.

2.5 Conceptual framework

The theoretical combination is successfully transformed into an empirically testable sequence within the conceptual framework; however, destination branding would not work according to a strictly created linear formula. The branding communication of CNTB, or Croatian National Tourism Board, can be perceived as the primary engine towards building Croatia's identity in terms of communicated attributes, values, personality, USPs, and cultural or natural representations (Chen et al., 2023). The aforementioned representations are perceived in conjunction with the already known information regarding the tourism sector of the destination, creating a perceived destination image consisting of cognitive, emotive, and overall evaluations. Recent study-derived evidence points to the inconsistency of projected and perceived images: the analysis of over 110098 official promotional texts and reviews of tourists showed that while the official communication refers to a broad understanding of the destination, tourists tend to focus on specific attractions with socio-cultural and environmental meanings (Chen et al., 2023).

The main analytical instrument is thus represented as the concept of identity–image alignment or gap, instead of presuming that effective communication can lead automatically to the desired image. This differentiation is significant since alignment is understood as the empirical relationship which should be studied instead of being considered as a predetermined result (Lin et al., 2026). In recent research, the projected-perceived gap is indicated as the unsolved problem in destination branding, while new studies claim that image constituents act together but not independently. The approach then connects alignment to the strategy's outputs, including differentiation, competitiveness,

and destination brand equity, while also applying these conclusions to diversification and sustainable tourism (Lin et al., 2026). The application is justified by recent findings that show the dimensions of destination brand equity may affect tourist behaviours and sustainable tourism results. However, the approach does not claim that branding alone leads to sustainability; instead, sustainability is seen as a potential accomplishment of the strategy, depending on the way the destination is perceived and experienced (Lin et al., 2026).

From a methodological perspective, the framework underpins the mixed-methods design of the study. The qualitative part addresses CNTB marketing materials and stakeholder perspectives for understanding how the projected identity of the Croatian destination is formulated, while the quantitative survey assesses the perceived image of international travellers, their experiences, and evaluations regarding the destination brand (Chiwariidzo & Chiwaridzo, 2024). Combining these two types of evidence allows for comparing the projected identity with tourists' perceptions and identifying the points of alignment or discrepancy. Based on the interpretation obtained, recommendations relating to positioning, differentiation, diversification, and sustainable tourism development can be formulated (Pongsakornrunsilp et al., 2021). Therefore, the framework ensures that there is a logical flow from the theoretical concepts developed in Chapter 2 to the subsequent qualitative and quantitative methods that are also explained in Chapter 3.

Figure 1: Conceptual Framework

(Source: Self-created)

2.6 Conclusion

As per the findings of the literature review, destination branding is more than simple marketing communication; it includes the understanding of the destination identity or the perception of travellers and its relationships to strategic marketing, differentiation, and brand value. Yet, there is a significant void in integrating the relationship between the projected identity of Croatia as a tourist destination and how it is perceived internationally, especially in terms of their effects on strategic positioning, diversification, and sustainable tourism. The four theoretical approaches refer to different stages of this connection-Hankinson relates to the relational brand system, Kapferer deals with the structure of identity, Baloglu and McCleary discuss image formation, and Aaker investigates the brand equity effects. Thus, Chapter 3 of the dissertation conducts the appropriate operationalisation of the mentioned relationships.

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1.	with	Wrong or missing prepositions	Correctness
2.	, such	Incorrect punctuation	Correctness